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RICHARD WRIGHT
1908–1960

A summary of Richard Wright's life is captured in the title of an early critical article on his work: "Juvenile Delinquent Becomes Famous Writer." Born in 1908 on a plantation near Natchez, Mississippi, Wright's life conformed to the stock pattern of the American success myth. From his impoverished and educationally barren early years to his achievement as a favored literary touchstone and ancestor figure, the details of Wright's life constitute the stuff of legends.

Wright's early life gave him bitter preparation for the intellectual outlook and the acute social and political consciousness of his writing. Shuttled from relative to relative, after his mother's partial paralysis forced her to place him and his brother temporarily in an orphanage, Wright lived a time with his grandmother and aunt, whose religious fanaticism stunted Wright's education but not his passion for encyclopedic reading. Working in Memphis as an errand boy, Wright fed this obsession, subverting Jim Crow laws by forging the now famous note to a public librarian: "Dear Madam: Will you please let this nigger boy have some books by H. L. Mencken?" Although Wright also read the fiction of Theodore Dreiser, Sherwood Anderson, and Sinclair Lewis and shared their indictments of middle-class babbitry, it was Mencken's work that first inspired Wright's own literary ambitions and focused his own aspirations as a stylist. From Mencken's *A Book of Prefaces,* Wright sensed a man "fighting, fighting with words . . . using words as a weapon . . . as one would use a club." Wright would later supplement this early reading with the work of experimentalists and modernists such as Marcel Proust, Henry James, and Gertrude Stein, whose character Melanctha from *Three Lives,* Wright considered one of the few credible portraits of an African American by a white author.

In 1927 Wright migrated to Chicago, along with masses of other blacks who fled the racism, poverty, and lynch law of the rural South only to find the cities of the urban North, as he put it, "sprawling centers of steel and stone" as cold and unyielding as the South. Disabused of his expectation that life in the North "could be lived with dignity," Wright turned to Communism and began to find a literary voice and ideological affinity in the leftist political ferment of the 1930s. He eventually broke with the Communist Party in 1942 because of its weak position on discrimination in the armed forces during World War II and because of its attempts to control his writing. The break became public and official in 1944 when he published excerpts of "I Tried to Be a Communist" in *Atlantic Monthly,* but it was far from precipitous. Well up to the publication of *Twelve Million Black Voices* (1941), Wright had tried to sharpen his conception of literary form and to work out the relationship between the techniques of fiction and the tenets of Marxism. He attended meetings of the Chicago John Reed Club and served as chief Harlem correspondent for the *Daily Worker,* while churning out proletarian poems for such Communist journals as *New Masses* and *Partisan Review.* It followed logically from these experiences that Wright would try his own hand at outlining a literary theory with broad claims for African American writers. The result was "Blueprint for Negro Writing." Published in the inaugural issue of *New Challenge* (1937), a magazine Wright co-edited with Dorothy West and Marian Minus, "Blueprint," was, like Langston Hughes's earlier "The Negro Artist and the Racial Mountain," a manifesto and declaration of independence from what Wright judged to be the hidebound bourgeois literary forms and agendas that had long dominated black letters. Distancing himself from the writings of the Harlem Renaissance, which he dismissed as "humble novels, poems,

and plays," written by "prim and decorous ambassadors who went a-begging to white America," Wright urged black writers to embrace a Marxist conception of reality and society, which offered, in his judgment, the "maximum degree of freedom in thought and feeling . . . for the Negro writer."

Wright executed his own blueprint in *Uncle Tom's Children* (1938), a collection of four novellas set in the Jim Crow South. His blueprint worked, at the expense of the stories, which are often flawed by Marxist propagandizing, melodrama, ponderous didacticism, and improbable plots. These stories show some of the major influences on Wright's fiction: naturalism, Marxism, Freudianism, and the black folk tradition, with the latter of which Wright had a contradictory relationship that lasted throughout his career.

"Long Black Song" is one of the few works by Wright written from the perspective of a woman. It is believed to be based on the tragedy of his uncle Hoskins, a successful bar owner in Elaine, Arkansas, who was murdered by whites who wanted possession of his business and his land. Critics have often praised its somber lyricism, reminiscent of Jean Toomer's "Blood Burning Moon," a tale of an interracial triangle, and also noticed the extent to which "Long Black Song" fits a pattern dominant in Wright's work: the marginality of women, who figure merely as accessories to the larger political and philosophical themes of his fiction. In this story, as novelist and critic Sherley Anne Williams notes, Wright represents the rape of Sarah not as a violation of *her* body, but rather, as an affront to her husband's pride and masculinity.

Uncle Tom's Children brought Wright first prize in a competition among writers of the Works Progress Administration (WPA) as well as a Guggenheim fellowship; this success enabled him to work exclusively on his writing. Despite its success, at least with some critics, Wright was himself harshly critical of the collection. Characterizing it as a sentimental work, which "even bankers' daughters could read and weep over and feel good about," he vowed that his next novel would be one "so hard and deep that [readers] would have to face it without the consolation of tears." That next novel was *Native Son*, which contained extremities of violence and horror not likely to inspire anything but fear. Indeed "Fear" was, significantly, the title Wright gave to the first of the book's three parts.

Native Son is widely considered Wright's most monumental achievement in fiction. In a now famous overstatement, critic Irving Howe declared, "The day *Native Son* appeared, American culture was changed forever." Whether one accepts Howe's judgment or not, it is certain that *Native Son* is not only the novel that established Richard Wright as a major literary talent of the twentieth century but also the novel whose mix of urban realism, sociological theory, and naturalistic determinism helped define and influence almost the entire sweep of African American fiction of the post–World War II era. It is significant that *Native Son* is also the novel that worked virtually to limit the critical response of Wright's entire corpus to a single category: protest writer. The book earned Wright the reputation as a writer who dared to expose the stresses and pathologies in the urban ghettoes in which poor blacks were confined. Equally significant is that *Native Son* made Wright the first African American writer to receive both critical acclaim and commercial success simultaneously.

Published by Harper & Brothers, *Native Son* was a Book-of-the-Month Club selection. Selling two hundred thousand copies inside of three weeks, the novel broke a twenty-year sales record for Harper's, beating out John Steinbeck's Pulitzer Prize–winning novel *The Grapes of Wrath*, as the number one best-seller. Although these impressive sales did not spell wealth or even financial security for Wright—he would struggle to support himself for the duration of his career—the novel proved a paradox. As notes critic Lawrence Jackson, *Native Son* established that "black American themes could create a national buzz, meriting their adoption by the major presses" and, at the same time, that "Negro writers were still a world apart, too 'special' in their direction to become blockbuster sellers."

Native Son shows a mix of aesthetic forms and traditions. The novel combined the determinism of naturalism with the grittiness of socialist realism that Wright drew from the works of such writers as James T. Farrell and Theodore Dreiser. Dreiser's *An American Tragedy*, to which *Native Son* is frequently compared, had an especial impact on Wright's literary development and philosophical outlook. He would later write in *Black Boy*, his autobiography: "I was overwhelmed. . . . It would have been impossible for me to have told anyone what I derived from these novels. All my life has shaped me for the, the naturalism of the modern novel." Of course, by the time Wright made that statement, the aesthetics of modernism, which had revolutionized so many of the arts in America, was an established fact of literary life. For Wright, however, realism and naturalism remained vital forces in his work. While clearly influenced by these traditions, Wright, as his more perceptive critics have noted, was also influenced by the tradition of the Gothic romance, employed by such nineteenth-century American writers as Nathaniel Hawthorne and Edgar Allan Poe. Still others have noted that the language of symbolism in Wright's work brings him closer to the tradition of modernism than is generally acknowledged.

Whatever modernist elements are to be found in Wright's work are arguably eclipsed by his overwhelming investments in the Chicago School of sociology and the deterministic slants of its theories. He acknowledged that the Chicago School provided him the explanatory concepts and theoretical frameworks for his fiction. Indeed the Chicago School provided the shaping apparatus not only for *Native Son* but also for *Twelve Million Black Voices*. Published a year after *Native Son* in 1941, *Twelve Million Black Voices* was subtitled "A Folk History of the American Negro." Based on photographs culled from the Farm Security Administration files, the book features Wright's running commentary throughout the text, explaining the crippling effects of the Great Migration on southern blacks. In an idea that structured his entire text, Wright supposed that the forces affecting black life in the North, as in the South, were all attributable to property ownership. "The Lords of the Land" in the agrarian South and the "Bosses of Buildings" in the industrial North were alike in exacting a heavy toll of oppression and death on blacks who were "landless upon the land" in the South and constricted in kitchenette apartments in the North.

The fame that Wright earned in the early 1940s, chiefly engendered by *Native Son*, led to extensive lecturing and travel. He spoke around the country and, in 1942, was awarded the NAACP's Spingarn Medal, then the most prestigious award for achievements by any African American in the country. A successful stage production of *Native Son* (1941), which Wright himself adapted, toured the country after a brief Broadway run. But Wright was clearly not content to have his literary reputation rest on *Native Son* alone or entirely on the prerogatives of socialist realism. The publication of his autobiography, *Black Boy*, in 1945 indicated a new direction.

Hailed as a masterpiece, *Black Boy* was praised for its achievement of a tautness and lyric intensity generally smothered in Wright's work by ideological abstractions. Writing in the militant spirit of Frederick Douglass's 1845 *Narrative* and drawing on a number of slave narrative conventions, Wright succeeded in fashioning a myth of self that conformed to the stock pattern of the American success myth of the self-made man, of which Benjamin Franklin's *Autobiography* and Douglass's *Narrative* are prototypical examples. *Black Boy* sold as vigorously upon release as had *Native Son* five years before. Four months after its release, the book had sold 450,000 copies, making it the leading nonfiction best-seller in the nation at the time. When he reviewed the book, Ralph Ellison judged *Black Boy* a "personal catastrophe expressed lyrically." Cheering Wright as a "black boy singing lustily as he probes his own grievous wound," Ellison predicted that the book would "do much to redefine the problem of the Negro and American Democracy."

Following the publication of *Black Boy* Wright expatriated to Paris, where he remained until his premature death in 1960. As such recent scholars as William J. Maxwell have suggested, Wright's decampment to France was likely motivated, at least in part, by the FBI surveillance to which he and other African American writers,

In *Twelve Million Black Voices*, Wright drew upon the archive of photographs taken by photographers in the employ of the Farm Security Administration.

including Baldwin, Lorraine Hansberry, and Langston Hughes, were subjected. State surveillance notwithstanding, Wright's sojourn in Paris inspired his famous quip: "there is more freedom in one block of Paris than there is in the whole United States." In Paris Wright became involved with Jean-Paul Sartre, Simone de Beauvoir, Albert Camus, and other members of *Les Temps Modernes* who are credited with, perhaps too uncritically, influencing the existentialist philosophy apparent in Wright's novel *The Outsider* (1953). Some critics suggest that Wright's traumatic childhood in Mississippi made him a "home-grown" existentialist, who had actually begun to incorporate the philosophy into his writing as early as 1944 when his short story "The Man Who Lived Underground" appeared in the anthology *Cross Section*. In both *The Outsider* and "The Man Who Lived Underground," Wright also indulged his lifelong fascination with the conventions of such popular genres as detective stories and dime novels.

Wright traveled throughout Europe and Africa in the 1950s and continued to be prolific in a variety of forms, but during this decade his imagination took an increasingly cosmopolitan turn, based on his travels as well as on his associations with various international luminaries. These included no less than Léopold Senghor, Senegalese poet, politician, and cultural theorist who served as the first president of Senegal from 1960 to 1980; Aimé Césaire, French poet, author and politician from Martinique, and founding member of the Negritude movement in Francophone literature; Jawaharlal Nehru, first prime minister of independent India; and Kwame Nkrumah, who would lead the Gold Coast to nationhood in 1957 and the new West African state of Ghana. George and Dorothy Padmore, Pan-Africanist leftists committed to independence movements in Africa, had urged Wright to visit the Gold Coast in 1953. On the basis of his extensive travels there, Wright wrote *Black Power: A Record of Reactions in a Land of Pathos* (1954), in which he recorded his impressions of the social and psychological effects of material oppression in global perspective. Though often credited for its participation in Pan-Africanist and anticolonialist projects, as well as for its investments in the promise of black emancipation worldwide, *Black Power* has been critiqued just as often for "colonialist" impulses, evident in its condescending assertions about African cultural practices. On the heels of *Black Power* came *The Color Curtain: A Report on the Bandung Conference* (1956). Wright attended the spring 1955 Bandung Conference of nonaligned Asian and African nations in Indonesia as a reporter for *Encounter*—in which venue Baldwin's coverage of the First International Congress of Black Writers and Artists would appear in 1956. Alongside his old antagonist, Wright also participated in that congress at the Sorbonne where he delivered the closing address, "Tradition and Industrialization." The essay, which bears the provocative subtitle "The Historic Meaning of the Plight of the Tragic Elite in Africa," calls Wright's putative anticolonialist credentials into question. Although some might stop short of endorsing Henry Louis Gates's argument that Wright's essay is a "blueprint for a neocolonialist police state," there is much merit in his critique of Wright's overinvestment in Western notions of modernity which Wright regarded as the blessed obverse of "tradition," presumably embodied by non-Western nations. Critics have wrestled with Wright's celebratory idea that the West was a welcomed corrective to "tradition," in that it helped "smash the irrational ties of religion and custom and tradition in Asia and Africa." No less troubling is the essay's statement: "WHAT IS GOOD FOR EUROPE IS GOOD FOR ALL MANKIND" (emphasis in the original). Although the essay is clearly irreducible to these excerpts, the ambiguities they create in the writings of one otherwise so openly critical of Western domination must be noted. Perhaps one of the essay's saving graces lies in Wright's observation that the congress attendance was dramatically absent of visible women participants:

> I would like to say—I don't know how many of you have noticed it (sic) there have been no women functioning vitally and responsibly upon this platform helping to mold and mobilize our thoughts. This is not a criticism of the conference, it is not a criticism of anyone, it is a criticism that I heap upon ourselves collectively.

> When and if we hold another conference—and I hope we will—I hope there shall be an effective utilization of Negro womanhood in the world to help us mobilize and pool our forces.

A remarkable statement in any event, but coming from Richard Wright and from the perspective of the traditional criticism lodged against the treatment of women in his fictional plots, it is weighty enough to provoke a reconsideration of this phase of Wright's career, if not the whole. "Tradition and Industrialization" might be said to belong to Wright's "international" years, insofar as the topics of his address are no longer strictly centered on African American life and thought but, rather, reflect on the broader currents of the global political scene.

"Tradition and Industrialization" underwent subtle revisions and modifications of its most troubling passages before its inclusion in Wright's collection of essays *White Man Listen!* (1957) In *Pagan Spain* (1957) Wright rounded out perhaps his most productive decade, during which he published not only his trilogy of travel books—*Black Power, The Color Curtain,* and *Pagan Spain*—but also three novels—*The Outside* (1953), *Savage Holiday* (1954), and *The Long Dream* (1958).

Despite this prodigious output, however, many critics have argued that Wright's career as a serious literary artist ended in 1946, when he left the United States. While France and French citizenship liberated Wright as a person, they argue, it shackled his creative expression, dulling the vivid memories of his childhood and early life, deadening his ear to the rhythms and cadences of black American speech, all of which he had captured so compellingly in such works as "The Ethics of Living Jim Crow" and *Black Boy.* The result, for some, was work that seemed contrived and artificial, full of windy abstractions. Such criticisms, which verge on dictating the range and limits of Wright's imagination to African American life and culture, fail to give proper due to Wright's growing awareness of a world emerging from Western and American hegemony of which his life as an émigré had made him keenly aware.

During the last decade of his life and career, Wright devoted much of his work to exploring this emergent world order, however troubling some of his conclusions might be. That he attempted to chart this shifting order and to describe the emancipatory movements by linking those oppressed behind the "color curtains" around the globe, including the Jim Crow South, is not easily dismissed. Indeed, Wright's preoccupations with black nationalist, independence movements in Africa formed a bridge connecting him again across the Atlantic to the black aesthetic critics and writers of the late 1960s who claimed Wright as a favored ancestor and who suggested that without *Native Son*, no viable African American literary tradition would have been possible. Like most critics before them, the black aestheticians designated Wright a "protest" writer par excellence, finding in his work the "clenched militancy" that Irving Howe had praised at the expense of Ralph Ellison and James Baldwin.

The full extent and importance of Wright's artistic contributions to African American literature are still being assessed in light of the contemporary editions of his work that restore expurgated passages originally perceived to be too raw and sexually explicit for American reading audiences of the time. The restored passages of *Native Son*, for example, now lead critics to underline the homoerotic aspects of that novel, only hinted at in the original. Similarly, Wright's autobiography, structured originally in two parts, appeared separately in two parts as *Black Boy* in 1945 and posthumously as *American Hunger.* The Library of America edition brought the two together for the first time. Finally, the restoration of lengthy editorial cuts made originally in *The Outsider* provides a stronger sense of the style, which Wright called "poetic realism," toward which he was groping in this work. Finally, with the posthumous novel, *A Father's Law* (2008), on which he was working during the last months of his life, he had circled back to the genre of crime fiction that brought him his fame.

Even without these invaluable new editions of Wright's work, it would continue to be read. *Native Son* made sure of that. If Wright had produced nothing else, the novel would have secured and solidified his reputation. Although critics have disagreed, often bitterly, over the artistic merits of *Native Son*, none deny its power. Though

compromised by ideological commitments and marred by overwriting, the novel's class consciousness, its exploration of sexual racism and social dislocation, and its rejection of the dominant discourse on race guarantee the novel's lasting significance and Wright's place in world letters.

Blueprint for Negro Writing

1) The Role of Negro Writing: Two Definitions

Generally speaking, Negro writing in the past has been confined to humble novels, poems, and plays, prim and decorous ambassadors who went a-begging to white America. They entered the Court of American Public Opinion dressed in the knee-pants of servility, curtsying to show that the Negro was not inferior, that he was human, and that he had a life comparable to that of other people. For the most part these artistic ambassadors were received as though they were French poodles who do clever tricks.

White America never offered these Negro writers any serious criticism. The mere fact that a Negro could write was astonishing. Nor was there any deep concern on the part of white America with the role Negro writing should play in American culture; and the role it did play grew out of accident rather than intent or design. Either it crept in through the kitchen in the form of jokes; or it was the fruits of that foul soil which was the result of a liason between inferiority-complexed Negro "geniuses" and burnt-out white Bohemians with money.

On the other hand, these often technically brilliant performances by Negro writers were looked upon by the majority of literate Negroes as something to be proud of. At best, Negro writing has been something external to the lives of educated Negroes themselves. That the productions of their writers should have been something of a guide in their daily living is a matter which seems never to have been raised seriously.

Under these conditions Negro writing assumed two general aspects: 1) It became a sort of conspicuous ornamentation, the hallmark of "achievement." 2) It became the voice of the educated Negro pleading with white America for justice.

Rarely was the best of this writing addressed to the Negro himself, his needs, his sufferings, his aspirations. Through misdirection, Negro writers have been far better to others than they have been to themselves. And the mere recognition of this places the whole question of Negro writing in a new light and raises a doubt as to the validity of its present direction.

2) The Minority Outlook

Somewhere in his writings Lenin[1] makes the observation that oppressed minorities often reflect the techniques of the bourgeoisie more brilliantly than some sections of the bourgeoisie themselves. The psychological importance of this becomes meaningful when it is recalled that oppressed minorities, and especially the petty bourgeois sections of oppressed minorities, strive to assimilate the virtues of the bourgeoisie in the assumption that by doing so

1. Vladimir Ilyich Ulyanov (1870–1924), Communist theorist and founder of the Bolshevik Party. He was the leader of the newly formed Soviet Union until his death.

they can lift themselves into a higher social sphere. But not only among the oppressed petty bourgeoisie does this occur. The workers of a minority people, chafing under exploitation, forge organizational forms of struggle to better their lot. Lacking the handicaps of false ambition and property, they have access to a wide social vision and a deep social consciousness. They display a greater freedom and initiative in pushing their claims upon civilization than even do the petty bourgeoisie. Their organizations show greater strength, adaptability, and efficiency than any other group or class in society.

That Negro workers, propelled by the harsh conditions of their lives, have demonstrated this consciousness and mobility for economic and political action there can be no doubt. But has this consciousness been reflected in the work of Negro writers to the same degree as it has in the Negro workers' struggle to free Herndon and the Scottsboro Boys,[2] in the drive toward unionism, in the fight against lynching? Have they as creative writers taken advantage of their unique minority position?

The answer decidedly is *no.* Negro writers have lagged sadly, and as time passes the gap widens between them and their people.

How can this hiatus be bridged? How can the enervating effects of this long standing split be eliminated?

In presenting questions of this sort an attitude of self-consciousness and self-criticism is far more likely to be a fruitful point of departure than a mere recounting of past achievements. An emphasis upon tendency and experiment, a view of society as something becoming rather than as something fixed and admired is the one which points the way for Negro writers to stand shoulder to shoulder with Negro workers in mood and outlook.

3) *A Whole Culture*

There is, however, a culture of the Negro which is his and has been addressed to him; a culture which has, for good or ill, helped to clarify his consciousness and create emotional attitudes which are conducive to action. This culture has stemmed mainly from two sources: 1) the Negro church; 2) and the folklore of the Negro people.

It was through the portals of the church that the American Negro first entered the shrine of western culture. Living under slave conditions of life, bereft of his African heritage, the Negroes' struggle for religion on the plantations between 1820–60 assumed the form of a struggle for human rights. It remained a relatively revolutionary struggle until religion began to serve as an antidote for suffering and denial. But even today there are millions of American Negroes whose only sense of a whole universe, whose only relation to society and man, and whose only guide to personal dignity comes through the archaic morphology of Christian salvation.

2. Nine black youths tried for the alleged rape of two white women in 1931 in Alabama. All were convicted, and all but one were sentenced to death, despite expert medical testimony that no rape had occurred. Subsequent U.S. Supreme Court decisions (1932 and 1935) reversed the convictions. In further proceedings in Alabama from 1935 to 1937, four of the Scottsboro Nine were once again convicted, resulting in prison terms ranging from seventy-five years to life. Charges against the remaining five were dropped. The case was used by the Communist Party to shore up its support, as it fought the NAACP for the opportunity to represent the defendants. Angelo Herndon was the lead figure in what was, along with the trial of the Scottsboro Boys, one of the most celebrated criminal trials in African American history. Born in Ohio, Herndon was a member of the Communist Party. For organizing an antidiscrimination march in Georgia, he was convicted in 1933 of inciting insurrection and sentenced to a twenty-year prison term under a one-hundred-year-old slave law. The U.S. Supreme Court reversed this decision in 1937.

It was, however, in a folklore moulded out of rigorous and inhuman conditions of life that the Negro achieved his most indigenous and complete expression. Blues, spirituals, and folk tales recounted from mouth to mouth; the whispered words of a black mother to her black daughter on the ways of men; the confidential wisdom of a black father to his black son; the swapping of sex experiences on street corners from boy to boy in the deepest vernacular; work songs sung under blazing suns—all these formed the channels through which the racial wisdom flowed.

One would have thought that Negro writers in the last century of striving at expression would have continued and deepened this folk tradition, would have tried to create a more intimate and yet a more profoundly social system of artistic communication between them and their people. But the illusion that they could escape through individual achievement the harsh lot of their race swung Negro writers away from any such path. Two separate cultures sprang up: one for the Negro masses, unwritten and unrecognized; and the other for the sons and daughters of a rising Negro bourgeoisie, parasitic and mannered.

Today the question is: Shall Negro writing be for the Negro masses, moulding the lives and consciousness of those masses toward new goals, or shall it continue begging the question of the Negroes' humanity?

4) The Problem of Nationalism in Negro Writing

In stressing the difference between the role Negro writing failed to play in the lives of the Negro people, and the role it should play in the future if it is to serve its historic function; in pointing out the fact that Negro writing has been addressed in the main to a small white audience rather than to a Negro one, it should be stated that no attempt is being made here to propagate a specious and blatant nationalism. Yet the nationalist character of the Negro people is unmistakable. Psychologically this nationalism is reflected in the whole of Negro culture, and especially in folklore.

In the absence of fixed and nourishing forms of culture, the Negro has a folklore which embodies the memories and hopes of his struggle for freedom. Not yet caught in paint or stone, and as yet but feebly depicted in the poem and novel, the Negroes' most powerful images of hope and despair still remain in the fluid state of daily speech. How many John Henrys[3] have lived and died on the lips of these black people? How many mythical heroes in embryo have been allowed to perish for lack of husbanding by alert intelligence?

Negro folklore contains, in a measure that puts to shame more deliberate forms of Negro expression, the collective sense of Negro life in America. Let those who shy at the nationalist implications of Negro life look at this body of folklore, living and powerful, which rose out of a unified sense of a common life and a common fate. Here are those vital beginnings of a recognition of value in life as it is *lived,* a recognition that marks the emergence of a new culture in the shell of the old. And at the moment this process starts, at the moment when a people begin to realize a *meaning* in their suffering, the civilization that engenders that suffering is doomed.

The nationalist aspects of Negro life are as sharply manifest in the social institutions of Negro people as in folklore. There is a Negro church, a Negro

3. A legendary figure from African American ballads and folklore. In the story, John Henry competed with a steam-powered drill to drive railroad spikes. He won the contest but died from exhaustion.

press, a Negro social world, a Negro sporting world, a Negro business world, a Negro school system, Negro professions; in short, a Negro way of life in America. The Negro people did not ask for this, and deep down, though they express themselves through their institutions and adhere to this special way of life, they do not want it now. This special existence was forced upon them from without by lynch rope, bayonet and mob rule. They accepted these negative conditions with the inevitability of a tree which must live or perish in whatever soil it finds itself.

The few crumbs of American civilization which the Negro has got from the tables of capitalism have been through these segregated channels. Many Negro institutions are cowardly and incompetent; but they are all that the Negro has. And, in the main, any move, whether for progress or reaction, must come through these institutions for the simple reason that all other channels are closed. Negro writers who seek to mould or influence the consciousness of the Negro people must address their messages to them through the ideologies and attitudes fostered in this warping way of life.

5) *The Basis and Meaning of Nationalism in Negro Writing*

The social institutions of the Negro are imprisoned in the Jim Crow[4] political system of the South, and this Jim Crow political system is in turn built upon a plantation-feudal economy. Hence, it can be seen that the emotional expression of group-feeling which puzzles so many whites and leads them to deplore what they call "black chauvinism" is not a morbidly inherent trait of the Negro, but rather the reflex expression of a life whose roots are imbedded deeply in Southern soil.

Negro writers must accept the nationalist implications of their lives, not in order to encourage them, but in order to change and transcend them. They must accept the concept of nationalism because, in order to transcend it, they must *possess* and *understand* it. And a nationalist spirit in Negro writing means a nationalism carrying the highest possible pitch of social consciousness. It means a nationalism that knows its origins, its limitations; that is aware of the dangers of its position; that knows its ultimate aims are unrealizable within the framework of capitalist America; a nationalism whose reason for being lies in the simple fact of self-possession and in the consciousness of the interdependence of people in modern society.

For purposes of creative expression it means that the Negro writer must realize within the area of his own personal experience those impulses which, when prefigured in terms of broad social movements, constitute the stuff of nationalism.

For Negro writers even more so than for Negro politicians, nationalism is a bewildering and vexing question, the full ramifications of which cannot be dealt with here. But among Negro workers and the Negro middle class the spirit of nationalism is rife in a hundred devious forms; and a simple literary realism which seeks to depict the lives of these people devoid of wider social connotations, devoid of the revolutionary significance of these nationalist tendencies, must of necessity do a rank injustice to the Negro people and alienate their possible allies in the struggle for freedom.

4. System of social segregation in the U.S. South during the late 19th and the 20th centuries.

6) Social Consciousness and Responsibility

The Negro writer who seeks to function within his race as a purposeful agent has a serious responsibility. In order to do justice to his subject matter, in order to depict Negro life in all of its manifold and intricate relationships, a deep, informed, and complex consciousness is necessary; a consciousness which draws for its strength upon the fluid lore of a great people, and moulds this lore with the concepts that move and direct the forces of history today.

With the gradual decline of the moral authority of the Negro church, and with the increasing irresolution which is paralyzing Negro middle class leadership, a new role is devolving upon the Negro writer. He is being called upon to do no less than create values by which his race is to struggle, live and die.

By his ability to fuse and make articulate the experiences of men, because his writing possesses the potential cunning to steal into the inmost recesses of the human heart, because he can create the myths and symbols that inspire a faith in life, he may expect either to be consigned to oblivion, or to be recognized for the valued agent he is.

This raises the question of the personality of the writer. It means that in the lives of Negro writers must be found those materials and experiences which will create a meaningful picture of the world today. Many young writers have grown to believe that a Marxist analysis of society presents such a picture. It creates a picture which, when placed before the eyes of the writer, should unify his personality, organize his emotions, buttress him with a tense and obdurate will to change the world.

And, in turn, this changed world will dialectically change the writer. Hence, it is through a Marxist conception of reality and society that the maximum degree of freedom in thought and feeling can be gained for the Negro writer. Further, this dramatic Marxist vision, when consciously grasped, endows the writer with a sense of dignity which no other vision can give. Ultimately, it restores to the writer his lost heritage, that is, his role as a creator of the world in which he lives, and as a creator of himself.

Yet, for the Negro writer, Marxism is but the starting point. No theory of life can take the place of life. After Marxism has laid bare the skeleton of society, there remains the task of the writer to plant flesh upon those bones out of his will to live. He may, with disgust and revulsion, say *no* and depict the horrors of capitalism encroaching upon the human being. Or he may, with hope and passion, say *yes* and depict the faint stirrings of a new and emerging life. But in whatever social voice he chooses to speak, whether positive or negative, there should always be heard or *over*-heard his faith, his necessity, his judgement.

His vision need not be simple or rendered in primer-like terms; for the life of the Negro people is not simple. The presentation of their lives should be simple, yes; but all the complexity, the strangeness, the magic wonder of life that plays like a bright sheen over the most sordid existence, should be there. To borrow a phrase from the Russians, it should have a *complex simplicity.* Eliot, Stein, Joyce, Proust, Hemingway, and Anderson; Gorky, Barbusse, Nexo, and Jack London[5] no less than the folklore of the Negro himself

5. American writer (1876–1916). T. S. Eliot (1888–1965), American poet, playwright, and literary critic. Gertrude Stein (1874–1946), American-born author who later settled in Paris, where her home became the social center for a group of American and European artists. James Joyce (1882–1941), Irish novelist and poet. Marcel Proust (1871–1922), French novelist, essayist, and critic. Ernest Hemingway (1899–1961), American writer. Sherwood Anderson (1876–1941), American writer. Maxim Gorky (1868–1935), Russian prose writer and playwright. Henri Barbusse (1874–1935), French novelist and journalist. Martin Anderson Nexo (1869–1954), Danish novelist.

should form the heritage of the Negro writer. Every iota of gain in human thought and sensibility should be ready grist for his mill, no matter how far-fetched they may seem in their immediate implications.

7) *The Problem of Perspective*

What vision must Negro writers have before their eyes in order to feel the impelling necessity for an about face? What angle of vision can show them all the forces of modern society in process, all the lines of economic development converging toward a distant point of hope? Must they believe in some "ism"?

They may feel that only dupes believe in "isms"; they feel with some measure of justification that another commitment means only another disillusionment. But anyone destitute of a theory about the meaning, structure and direction of modern society is a lost victim in a world he cannot understand or control.

But even if Negro writers found themselves through some "ism," how would that influence their writing? Are they being called upon to "preach"? To be "salesmen"? To "prostitute" their writing? Must they "sully" themselves? Must they write "propaganda"?

No; it is a question of awareness, of consciousness; it is, above all, a question of perspective.

Perspective is that part of a poem, novel, or play which a writer never puts directly upon paper. It is that fixed point in intellectual space where a writer stands to view the struggles, hopes, and sufferings of his people. There are times when he may stand too close and the result is a blurred vision. Or he may stand too far away and the result is a neglect of important things.

Of all the problems faced by writers who as a whole have never allied themselves with world movements, perspective is the most difficult of achievement. At its best, perspective is a pre-conscious assumption, something which a writer takes for granted, something which he wins through his living.

A Spanish writer recently spoke of living in the heights of one's time. Surely, perspective means just *that*.

It means that a Negro writer must learn to view the life of a Negro living in New York's Harlem or Chicago's South Side with the consciousness that one-sixth of the earth surface belongs to the working class. It means that a Negro writer must create in his readers' minds a relationship between a Negro woman hoeing cotton in the South and the men who loll in swivel chairs in Wall Street and take the fruits of her toil.

Perspective for Negro writers will come when they have looked and brooded so hard and long upon the harsh lot of their race and compared it with the hopes and struggles of minority peoples everywhere that the cold facts have begun to tell them something.

8) *The Problem of Theme*

This does not mean that a Negro writer's sole concern must be with rendering the social scene; but if his conception of the life of his people is broad and deep enough, if the sense of the *whole* life he is seeking is vivid and strong in him, then his writing will embrace all those social, political, and economic forms under which the life of his people is manifest.

In speaking of theme one must necessarily be general and abstract; the temperament of each writer moulds and colors the world he sees. Negro life may be approached from a thousand angles, with no limit to technical and stylistic freedom.

Negro writers spring from a family, a clan, a class, and a nation; and the social units in which they are bound have a story, a record. Sense of theme will emerge in Negro writing when Negro writers try to fix this story about some pole of meaning, remembering as they do so that in the creative process meaning proceeds *equally* as much from the contemplation of the subject matter as from the hopes and apprehensions that rage in the heart of the writer.

Reduced to its simplest and most general terms, theme for Negro writers will rise from understanding the meaning of their being transplanted from a "savage" to a "civilized" culture in all of its social, political, economic, and emotional implications. It means that Negro writers must have in their consciousness the foreshortened picture of the *whole,* nourishing culture from which they were torn in Africa, and of the long, complex (and for the most part, unconscious) struggle to regain in some form and under alien conditions of life a *whole* culture again.

It is not only this picture they must have, but also a knowledge of the social and emotional milieu that gives it tone and solidity of detail. Theme for Negro writers will emerge when they have begun to feel the meaning of the history of their race as though they in one life time had lived it themselves throughout all the long centuries.

9) Autonomy of Craft

For the Negro writer to depict this new reality requires a greater discipline and consciousness than was necessary for the so-called Harlem school[6] of expression. Not only is the subject matter dealt with far more meaningful and complex, but the new role of the writer is qualitatively different. The Negro writers' new position demands a sharper definition of the status of his craft, and a sharper emphasis upon its functional autonomy.

Negro writers should seek through the medium of their craft to play as meaningful a role in the affairs of men as do other professionals. But if their writing is demanded to perform the social office of other professions, then the autonomy of craft is lost and writing detrimentally fused with other interests. The limitations of the craft constitute some of its greatest virtues. If the sensory vehicle of imaginative writing is required to carry too great a load of didactic material, the artistic sense is submerged.

The relationship between reality and the artistic image is not always direct and simple. The imaginative conception of a historical period will not be a carbon copy of reality. Image and emotion possess a logic of their own. A vulgarized simplicity constitutes the greatest danger in tracing the reciprocal interplay between the writer and his environment.

Writing has its professional autonomy; it should complement other professions, but it should not supplant them or be swamped by them.

6. Designation given those writers who took their subject matter from the black working classes and their language from the rhythms and inflections of black speech.

10) The Necessity for Collective Work

It goes without saying that these things cannot be gained by Negro writers if their present mode of isolated writing and living continues. This isolation exists *among* Negro writers as well as *between* Negro and white writers. The Negro writers' lack of thorough integration with the American scene, their lack of a clear realization among themselves of their possible role, have bred generation after generation of embittered and defeated literati.

Barred for decades from the theater and publishing houses, Negro writers have been *made* to feel a sense of difference. So deep has this white-hot iron of exclusion been burnt into their hearts that thousands have all but lost the desire to become identified with American civilization. The Negro writers' acceptance of this enforced isolation and their attempt to justify it is but a defense-reflex of the whole special way of life which has been rammed down their throats.

This problem, by its very nature, is one which must be approached contemporaneously from *two* points of view. The ideological unity of Negro writers and the alliance of that unity with all the progressive ideas of our day is the primary prerequisite for collective work. On the shoulders of white writers and Negro writers alike rest the responsibility of ending this mistrust and isolation.

By placing cultural health above narrow sectional prejudices, liberal writers of all races can help to break the stony soil of aggrandizement out of which the stunted plants of Negro nationalism grow. And, simultaneously, Negro writers can help to weed out these choking growths of reactionary nationalism and replace them with hardier and sturdier types.

These tasks are imperative in light of the fact that we live in a time when the majority of the most basic assumptions of life can no longer be taken for granted. Tradition is no longer a guide. The world has grown huge and cold. Surely this is the moment to ask questions, to theorize, to speculate, to wonder out of what materials can a human world be built.

Each step along this unknown path should be taken with thought, care, self-consciousness, and deliberation. When Negro writers think they have arrived at something which smacks of truth, humanity, they should want to test it with others, feel it with a degree of passion and strength that will enable them to communicate it to millions who are groping like themselves.

Writers faced with such tasks can have no possible time for malice or jealousy. The conditions for the growth of each writer depend too much upon the good work of other writers. Every first rate novel, poem, or play lifts the level of consciousness higher.

1937

The Ethics of Living Jim Crow,[1] an Autobiographical Sketch

I

My first lesson in how to live as a Negro came when I was quite small. We were living in Arkansas. Our house stood behind the railroad tracks. Its

1. System of social segregation in the U.S. South.

skimpy yard was paved with black cinders. Nothing green ever grew in that yard. The only touch of green we could see was far away, beyond the tracks, over where the white folks lived. But cinders were good enough for me and I never missed the green growing things. And anyhow, cinders were fine weapons. You could always have a nice hot war with huge black cinders. All you had to do was crouch behind the brick pillars of a house with your hands full of gritty ammunition. And the first woolly black head you saw pop out from behind another row of pillars was your target. You tried your very best to knock it off. It was great fun.

I never fully realized the appalling disadvantages of a cinder environment till one day the gang to which I belonged found itself engaged in a war with the white boys who lived beyond the tracks. As usual we laid down our cinder barrage, thinking that this would wipe the white boys out. But they replied with a steady bombardment of broken bottles. We doubled our cinder barrage, but they hid behind trees, hedges, and the sloping embankments of their lawns. Having no such fortifications, we retreated to the brick pillars of our homes. During the retreat a broken milk bottle caught me behind the ear, opening a deep gash which bled profusely. The sight of blood pouring over my face completely demoralized our ranks. My fellow-combatants left me standing paralyzed in the center of the yard, and scurried for their homes. A kind neighbor saw me and rushed me to a doctor, who took three stitches in my neck.

I sat brooding on my front steps, nursing my wound and waiting for my mother to come from work. I felt that a grave injustice had been done me. It was all right to throw cinders. The greatest harm a cinder could do was leave a bruise. But broken bottles were dangerous; they left you cut, bleeding, and helpless.

When night fell, my mother came from the white folks' kitchen. I raced down the street to meet her. I could just feel in my bones that she would understand. I knew she would tell me exactly what to do next time. I grabbed her hand and babbled out the whole story. She examined my wound, then slapped me.

"How come yuh didn't hide?" she asked me. "How come yuh awways fightin'?"

I was outraged, and bawled. Between sobs I told her that I didn't have any trees or hedges to hide behind. There wasn't a thing I could have used as a trench. And you couldn't throw very far when you were hiding behind the brick pillars of a house. She grabbed a barrel stave, dragged me home, stripped me naked, and beat me till I had a fever of one hundred and two. She would smack my rump with the stave, and, while the skin was still smarting, impart to me gems of Jim Crow wisdom. I was never to throw cinders any more. I was never to fight any more wars. I was never, never, under any conditions, to fight *white* folks again. And they were absolutely right in clouting me with the broken milk bottle. Didn't I know she was working hard every day in the hot kitchens of the white folks to make money to take care of me? When was I ever going to learn to be a good boy? She couldn't be bothered with my fights. She finished by telling me that I ought to be thankful to God as long as I lived that they didn't kill me.

All that night I was delirious and could not sleep. Each time I closed my eyes I saw monstrous white faces suspended from the ceiling, leering at me.

From that time on, the charm of my cinder yard was gone. The green trees, the trimmed hedges, the cropped lawns grew very meaningful, became a symbol. Even today when I think of white folks, the hard, sharp outlines of white houses surrounded by trees, lawns, and hedges are present somewhere in the background of my mind. Through the years they grew into an overreaching symbol of fear.

It was a long time before I came in close contact with white folks again. We moved from Arkansas to Mississippi. Here we had the good fortune not to live behind the railroad tracks, or close to white neighborhoods. We lived in the very heart of the local Black Belt. There were black churches and black preachers; there were black schools and black teachers; black groceries and black clerks. In fact, everything was so solidly black that for a long time I did not even think of white folks, save in remote and vague terms. But this could not last forever. As one grows older one eats more. One's clothing costs more. When I finished grammar school I had to go to work. My mother could no longer feed and clothe me on her cooking job.

There is but one place where a black boy who knows no trade can get a job, and that's where the houses and faces are white, where the trees, lawns, and hedges are green. My first job was with an optical company in Jackson, Mississippi. The morning I applied I stood straight and neat before the boss, answering all his questions with sharp yessirs and nosirs. I was very careful to pronounce my *sirs* distinctly, in order that he might know that I was polite, that I knew where I was, and that I knew he was a *white* man. I wanted that job badly.

He looked me over as though he were examining a prize poodle. He questioned me closely about my schooling, being particularly insistent about how much mathematics I had had. He seemed very pleased when I told him I had had two years of algebra.

"Boy, how would you like to try to learn something around here?" he asked me.

"I'd like it fine, sir," I said, happy. I had visions of "working my way up." Even Negroes have those visions.

"All right," he said. "Come on."

I followed him to the small factory.

"Pease," he said to a white man of about thirty-five, "this is Richard. He's going to work for us."

Pease looked at me and nodded.

I was then taken to a white boy of about seventeen.

"Morrie, this is Richard, who's going to work for us."

"Whut yuh sayin' there, boy!" Morrie boomed at me.

"Fine!" I answered.

The boss instructed these two to help me, teach me, give me jobs to do, and let me learn what I could in my spare time.

My wages were five dollars a week.

I worked hard, trying to please. For the first month I got along O.K. Both Pease and Morrie seemed to like me. But one thing was missing. And I kept thinking about it. I was not learning anything and nobody was volunteering to help me. Thinking they had forgotten that I was to learn something about the mechanics of grinding lenses, I asked Morrie one day to tell me about the work. He grew red.

"Whut yuh tryin' t' do, nigger, git smart?" he asked.

"Naw; I ain' tryin' t' git smart," I said.

"Well, don't, if yuh know whut's good for yuh!"

I was puzzled. Maybe he just doesn't want to help me, I thought. I went to Pease.

"Say, are you crazy, you black bastard?" Pease asked me, his gray eyes growing hard.

I spoke out, reminding him that the boss had said I was to be given a chance to learn something.

"Nigger, you think you're *white,* don't you?"

"Naw, sir!"

"Well, you're acting mighty like it!"

"But, Mr. Pease, the boss said . . ."

Pease shook his fist in my face.

"This is a *white* man's work around here, and you better watch yourself!"

From then on they changed toward me. They said goodmorning no more. When I was just a bit slow in performing some duty, I was called a lazy black son-of-a-bitch.

Once I thought of reporting all this to the boss. But the mere idea of what would happen to me if Pease and Morrie should learn that I had "snitched" stopped me. And after all, the boss was a white man, too. What was the use?

The climax came at noon one summer day. Pease called me to his workbench. To get to him I had to go between two narrow benches and stand with my back against a wall.

"Yes, sir," I said.

"Richard, I want to ask you something," Pease began pleasantly, not looking up from his work.

"Yes, sir," I said again.

Morrie came over, blocking the narrow passage between the benches. He folded his arms, staring at me solemnly.

I looked from one to the other, sensing that something was coming.

"Yes, sir," I said for the third time.

Pease looked up and spoke very slowly.

"Richard, *Mr.* Morrie here tells me you called me *Pease.*"

I stiffened. A void seemed to open up in me. I knew this was the showdown.

He meant that I had failed to call him *Mr.* Pease. I looked at Morrie. He was gripping a steel bar in his hands. I opened my mouth to speak, to protest, to assure Pease that I had never called him simply *Pease,* and that I had never had any intentions of doing so, when Morrie grabbed me by the collar, ramming my head against the wall.

"Now, be careful, nigger!" snarled Morrie, baring his teeth. "*I* heard yuh call 'im *Pease!* 'N' if yuh say yuh didn't, yuh're callin' me a *lie,* see?" He waved the steel bar threateningly.

If I had said: No, sir, Mr. Pease, I never called you *Pease,* I would have been automatically calling Morrie a liar. And if I had said: Yes, sir, Mr. Pease, I called you *Pease,* I would have been pleading guilty to having uttered the worst insult that a Negro can utter to a southern white man. I stood hesitating, trying to frame a neutral reply.

"Richard, I asked you a question!" said Pease. Anger was creeping into his voice.

"I don't remember calling you *Pease,* Mr. Pease," I said cautiously. "And if I did, I sure didn't mean . . ."

"You black son-of-a-bitch! You called me *Pease,* then!" he spat, slapping me till I bent sideways over a bench. Morrie was on top of me, demanding:

"Didn't yuh call 'im *Pease*? If yuh say yuh didn't, I'll rip yo' gut string loose with this bar, yuh black granny dodger! Yuh can't call a white man a lie 'n' git erway with it, you black son-of-a-bitch!"

I wilted. I begged them not to bother me. I knew what they wanted. They wanted me to leave.

"I'll leave," I promised. "I'll leave right *now.*"

They gave me a minute to get out of the factory. I was warned not to show up again, or tell the boss.

I went.

When I told the folks at home what had happened, they called me a fool. They told me that I must never again attempt to exceed my boundaries. When you are working for white folks, they said, you got to "stay in your place" if you want to keep working.

II

My Jim Crow education continued on my next job, which was portering in a clothing store. One morning, while polishing brass out front, the boss and his twenty-year-old son got out of their car and half dragged and half kicked a Negro woman into the store. A policeman standing at the corner looked on, twirling his nightstick. I watched out of the corner of my eye, never slackening the strokes of my chamois upon the brass. After a few minutes, I heard shrill screams coming from the rear of the store. Later the woman stumbled out, bleeding, crying, and holding her stomach. When she reached the end of the block, the policeman grabbed her and accused her of being drunk. Silently, I watched him throw her into a patrol wagon.

When I went to the rear of the store, the boss and his son were washing their hands at the sink. They were chuckling. The floor was bloody and strewn with wisps of hair and clothing. No doubt I must have appeared pretty shocked, for the boss slapped me reassuringly on the back.

"Boy, that's what we do to niggers when they don't want to pay their bills," he said, laughing.

His son looked at me and grinned.

"Here, hava cigarette," he said.

Not knowing what to do, I took it. He lit his and held the match for me. This was a gesture of kindness, indicating that even if they had beaten the poor old woman, they would not beat me if I knew enough to keep my mouth shut.

"Yes, sir," I said, and asked no questions.

After they had gone, I sat on the edge of a packing box and stared at the bloody floor till the cigarette went out.

That day at noon, while eating in a hamburger joint, I told my fellow Negro porters what had happened. No one seemed surprised. One fellow, after swallowing a huge bite, turned to me and asked:

"Huh! Is tha' all they did t' her?"

"Yeah. Wasn't tha' enough?" I asked.

"Shucks! Man, she's a lucky bitch!" he said, burying his lips deep into a juicy hamburger. "Hell, it's a wonder they didn't lay her when they got through."

III

I was learning fast, but not quite fast enough. One day, while I was delivering packages in the suburbs, my bicycle tire was punctured. I walked along the hot, dusty road, sweating and leading my bicycle by the handle-bars.

A car slowed at my side.

"What's the matter, boy?" a white man called.

I told him my bicycle was broken and I was walking back to town.

"That's too bad," he said. "Hop on the running board."

He stopped the car. I clutched hard at my bicycle with one hand and clung to the side of the car with the other.

"All set?"

"Yes, sir," I answered. The car started.

It was full of young white men. They were drinking. I watched the flask pass from mouth to mouth.

"Wanna drink, boy?" one asked.

I laughed as the wind whipped my face. Instinctively obeying the freshly planted precepts of my mother, I said:

"Oh, no!"

The words were hardly out of my mouth before I felt something hard and cold smash me between the eyes. It was an empty whisky bottle. I saw stars, and fell backwards from the speeding car into the dust of the road, my feet becoming entangled in the steel spokes of my bicycle. The white men piled out and stood over me.

"Nigger, ain' yuh learned no better sense'n tha' yet?" asked the man who hit me. "Ain' yuh learned t' say *sir* t' a white man yet?"

Dazed, I pulled to my feet. My elbows and legs were bleeding. Fists doubled, the white man advanced, kicking my bicycle out of the way.

"Aw, leave the bastard alone. He's got enough," said one.

They stood looking at me. I rubbed my shins, trying to stop the flow of blood. No doubt they felt a sort of contemptuous pity, for one asked:

"Yuh wanna ride t' town now, nigger? Yuh reckon yuh know enough t' ride now?"

"I wanna walk," I said, simply.

Maybe it sounded funny. They laughed.

"Well, walk, yuh black son-of-a-bitch!"

When they left they comforted me with:

"Nigger, yuh sho better be damn glad it wuz us yuh talked t' tha' way. Yuh're a lucky bastard, 'cause if yuh'd said tha' t' somebody else, yuh might've been a dead nigger now."

IV

Negroes who have lived South know the dread of being caught alone upon the streets in white neighborhoods after the sun has set. In such a simple situation as this the plight of the Negro in America is graphically symbolized. While white strangers may be in these neighborhoods trying to get home, they can pass unmolested. But the color of a Negro's skin makes him easily recognizable, makes him suspect, converts him into a defenseless target.

Late one Saturday night I made some deliveries in a white neighborhood. I was pedaling my bicycle back to the store as fast as I could, when a police car, swerving toward me, jammed me into the curbing.

"Get down and put up your hands!" the policemen ordered.

I did. They climbed out of the car, guns drawn, faces set, and advanced slowly.

"Keep still!" they ordered.

I reached my hands higher. They searched my pockets and packages. They seemed dissatisfied when they could find nothing incriminating. Finally, one of them said:

"Boy, tell your boss not to send you out in white neighborhoods after sundown."

As usual, I said:

"Yes, sir."

V

My next job was as hall-boy in a hotel. Here my Jim Crow education broadened and deepened. When the bell-boys were busy, I was often called to assist them. As many of the rooms in the hotel were occupied by prostitutes, I was constantly called to carry them liquor and cigarettes. These women were nude most of the time. They did not bother about clothing, even for bell-boys. When you went into their rooms, you were supposed to take their nakedness for granted, as though it startled you no more than a blue vase or a red rug. Your presence awoke in them no sense of shame, for you were not regarded as human. If they were alone, you could steal sidelong glimpses at them. But if they were receiving men, not a flicker of your eyelids could show. I remember one incident vividly. A new woman, a huge, snowy-skinned blonde, took a room on my floor. I was sent to wait upon her. She was in bed with a thick-set man; both were nude and uncovered. She said she wanted some liquor and slid out of bed and waddled across the floor to get her money from a dresser drawer. I watched her.

"Nigger, what in hell you looking at?" the white man asked me, raising himself upon his elbows.

"Nothing," I answered, looking miles deep into the blank wall of the room.

"Keep your eyes where they belong, if you want to be healthy!" he said.

"Yes, sir."

VI

One of the bell-boys I knew in this hotel was keeping steady company with one of the Negro maids. Out of a clear sky the police descended upon his home and arrested him, accusing him of bastardy. The poor boy swore he had had no intimate relations with the girl. Nevertheless, they forced him to marry her. When the child arrived, it was found to be much lighter in complexion than either of the two supposedly legal parents. The white men around the hotel made a great joke of it. They spread the rumor that some white cow must have scared the poor girl while she was carrying the baby. If you were in their presence when this explanation was offered, you were supposed to laugh.

VII

One of the bell-boys was caught in bed with a white prostitute. He was castrated and run out of town. Immediately after this all the bell-boys and hall-boys were called together and warned. We were given to understand that the boy who had been castrated was a "mighty, mighty lucky bastard." We were impressed with the fact that next time the management of the hotel would not be responsible for the lives of "trouble-makin' niggers." We were silent.

VIII

One night, just as I was about to go home, I met one of the Negro maids. She lived in my direction, and we fell in to walk part of the way home together. As we passed the white night-watchman, he slapped the maid on her buttock. I turned around, amazed. The watchman looked at me with a long, hard, fixed-under stare. Suddenly he pulled his gun and asked:

"Nigger, don't yuh like it?"

I hesitated.

"I asked yuh don't yuh like it?" he asked again, stepping forward.

"Yes, sir," I mumbled.

"Talk like it, then!"

"Oh, yes, sir!" I said with as much heartiness as I could muster.

Outside, I walked ahead of the girl, ashamed to face her. She caught up with me and said:

"Don't be a fool! Yuh couldn't help it!"

This watchman boasted of having killed two Negroes in self-defense.

Yet, in spite of all this, the life of the hotel ran with an amazing smoothness. It would have been impossible for a stranger to detect anything. The maids, the hall-boys, and the bell-boys were all smiles. They had to be.

IX

I had learned my Jim Crow lessons so thoroughly that I kept the hotel job till I left Jackson for Memphis. It so happened that while in Memphis I applied for a job at a branch of the optical company. I was hired. And for some reason, as long as I worked there, they never brought my past against me.

Here my Jim Crow education assumed quite a different form. It was no longer brutally cruel, but subtly cruel. Here I learned to lie, to steal, to dissemble. I learned to play that dual role which every Negro must play if he wants to eat and live.

For example, it was almost impossible to get a book to read. It was assumed that after a Negro had imbibed what scanty schooling the state furnished he had no further need for books. I was always borrowing books from men on the job. One day I mustered enough courage to ask one of the men to let me get books from the library in his name. Surprisingly, he consented. I cannot help but think that he consented because he was a Roman Catholic and felt a vague sympathy for Negroes, being himself an object of hatred. Armed with a library card, I obtained books in the following manner: I would write a note to the librarian, saying: "Please let this nigger boy have the following books." I would then sign it with the white man's name.

When I went to the library, I would stand at the desk, hat in hand, looking as unbookish as possible. When I received the books desired I would take them home. If the books listed in the note happened to be out, I would sneak into the lobby and forge a new one. I never took any chances guessing with the white librarian about what the fictitious white man would want to read. No doubt if any of the white patrons had suspected that some of the volumes they enjoyed had been in the home of a Negro, they would not have tolerated it for an instant.

The factory force of the optical company in Memphis was much larger than that in Jackson, and more urbanized. At least they liked to talk, and would engage the Negro help in conversation whenever possible. By this means I found that many subjects were taboo from the white man's point of view. Among the topics they did not like to discuss with Negroes were the following: American white women; the Ku Klux Klan; France, and how Negro soldiers fared while there; French women; Jack Johnson; the entire northern part of the United States; the Civil War; Abraham Lincoln; U. S. Grant; General Sherman; Catholics; the Pope; Jews; the Republican Party; slavery; social equality; Communism; Socialism; the 13th and 14th Amendments to the Constitution;[2] or any topic calling for positive knowledge or manly self-assertion on the part of the Negro. The most accepted topics were sex and religion.

There were many times when I had to exercise a great deal of ingenuity to keep out of trouble. It is a southern custom that all men must take off their hats when they enter an elevator. And especially did this apply to us blacks with rigid force. One day I stepped into an elevator with my arms full of packages. I was forced to ride with my hat on. Two white men stared at me coldly. Then one of them very kindly lifted my hat and placed it upon my armful of packages. Now the most accepted response for a Negro to make under such circumstances is to look at the white man out of the corner of his eye and grin. To have said: "Thank you!" would have made the white man *think* that you *thought* you were receiving from him a personal service. For such an act I have seen Negroes take a blow in the mouth. Finding the first alternative distasteful, and the second dangerous, I hit upon an acceptable course of action which fell safely between these two poles. I immediately—no sooner than my hat was lifted—pretended that my packages were about to spill, and appeared deeply distressed with keeping them in my arms. In this fashion I evaded having to acknowledge his service, and, in spite of adverse circumstances, salvaged a slender shred of personal pride.

How do Negroes feel about the way they have to live? How do they discuss it when alone among themselves? I think this question can be answered in a single sentence. A friend of mine who ran an elevator once told me:

"Lawd, man! Ef it wuzn't fer them polices 'n' them ol' lynch-mobs, there wouldn't be nothin' but uproar down here!"

1937

2. The Thirteenth Amendment (proclaimed December 18, 1865) abolished slavery and involuntary servitude, and the Fourteenth Amendment (proclaimed July 28, 1868) made American blacks citizens of the United States. Jack Johnson (1879–1946), black American heavyweight fighter who won the championship title in 1908.